high-profile, high-level reform committee. We're very clear in our intentions. Our government is committed to zero error."

Accepting "institutional failure in the NTA", Pradhan announced a high-level committee headed by K. Radhakrishnan, former chairman of the Indian Space Research Organisation, to study the agency's functioning and recommend reforms in two months. The government also removed IAS officer Subodh Kumar Singh as NTA director-general, appointing another IAS officer, Pradeep Singh Kharola, in his place. Investigation into all the allegations in NEET and UGC-NET have been handed to the CBI, with Pradhan asserting that "no one who is guilty will be spared". The government also announced the rules for a new central law that will impose severe penalties on those found guilty of exam malpractices, including question paper leaks and cheating.

A NEET COMPROMISE

Several facets of NEET 2024 have elicited significant public outcry. First was the extension of the registration window—twice after the month-long registration window had closed—which, it was argued, provided unfair advantage to some students. In fact, it was during this extension period that some of the 'toppers' had registered. This was followed by the unexpected advancement of the result date from June 14 to June 4, the day general election results would be announced, leading many to suspect that the date was chosen to deflect attention from the irregularities that were bound to surface.

The unusually high number of toppers, six of whom had seat numbers in the same sequence and took the test from a particular exam centre in Bahadurgarh, Haryana, is being seen as another anomaly. Incidentally, the centre, run by the wife of the local BJP youth wing chief, was plagued by issues on test day itself, with a mix-up in question papers leading to delays. Besides, some of these 'toppers' did not do well in their board exam, casting doubt over their NEET success.

The arbitrary awarding of grace marks by the NTA further complicated the situation. These were given to 1,563 students who allegedly lost time during the examination for various reasons or wrote wrong answers due to a printing error in an earlier version of a textbook. Following petitions in the Supreme Court, the NTA cancelled the marks and organised a re-test for the 1,563 students, but only 52 per cent took it.

Irregularities were also reported in several states, including Gujarat, Rajasthan and Bihar. Nearly two dozen people have been arrested in Gujarat, Bihar and Maharashtra for alleged involvement in paper leaks or other malpractices.

The controversy has also highlighted the suspected role of India's Rs 58,000 crore coaching industry in the manipulation of examinations. The alleged scam surfaced when students from Haryana, Bihar, Maharashtra, Jharkhand and Karnataka were found appearing for NEET at an obscure centre in Godhra. There were three protagonists here: Roy Overseas, a Vadodara-based coaching institute managed by Parshuram Roy; Purshottam Sharma, the principal of Jay

THE NEET IMBROGLIO

The NEET-UG is a pen-and-paper common entrance examination for the entire country. This year, 2,333,297 students appeared for the examination, vying for 109,170 seats in 706 medical colleges. Of these, 55,905 seats are available in 386 government medical colleges. Here is the process and where the lapses and breaches possibly occurred, putting the whole exam under question



1 Question Paper Setting

Subject experts are asked to create a pool of questions which are then reviewed and categorised by experienced educators and examiners to ensure they meet the required standards of difficulty and relevance, and cover the syllabus comprehensively

THE PROBLEM

The quality of the question paper this time was rendered suspect because an answer was deemed 'correct' even though it was wrong, owing to factual error in a textbook edition. Grace marks were awarded to compensate this

Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE